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OFFICE OF THE VICE PRESIDENT

WASHINGTON
April 14, 1993

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Meeting between Vice President Gore and President Alija Izetbegovic of Bosnia and Herzegovina

PARTICIPANTS: United States

The Vice President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Reginald Bartholomew, Special Envoy to the
Vance-Owen Talks
Leon Fuerth, Assistant to the Vice President for
National Security Affairs
Jane Holl, National Security Council Staff
Frank Pandolfe, Military Aide to the
Vice President (notetaker)

Bosnia

Alija Izetbegovic, President
Haris Silajdzic, Foreign Minister
Mohamed Sacirbey, Ambassador to the United Nations
Translator

PLACE: Vice President's West Wing Office

TIME: 10:50-11:45 a.m.

DATE: March 26, 1993

Vice President Gore: Welcome. President Clinton understands and appreciates your courage and statesmanship. I know what a difficult and decisive act it was. Events will unfold differently due to your courageous action. The key now will be to get the Bosnian Serbs to sign. Every effort will be made to make that happen, including a tightening of sanctions to increase pressure on the Serbs. We have to get Serb agreement in order to undertake implementation. In other nations, support for sanctions and diplomatically isolating the Serbs is very, very strong. All the more so now that you have signed the agreement. This is a turning point, but there is much left to be done. I know it has been a terrible burden for you to conduct negotiations while your people need relief. Your courage is helping achieve that step.

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President Izetbegovic: Our people lost confidence in the European Community. We appreciate the American commitment to backing implementation of this agreement. We know you will do your best to implement the agreement. I don't believe that Karadzic will sign. We must consider what to do if they do not sign. They should not be given much time, which they will use to continue killing and conducting massive attacks in Eastern Bosnia. These forces are coming from Serbia. Our information says that 200 tanks, troops, and training came from Serbia last month. This was to launch a new offensive. The international community must decide what it will do about this. The situation in Russia will complicate things. No one can predict what will happen there.

Bosnia is a democratic country, a democratic state. Karadzic says Serbs cannot live with other, that they must live alone in each town and village.

Vice President Gore: Our first step will be to make every effort to get Serbia to sign the agreement. But you're right that we must imagine what will happen if they don't sign. Also what will happen if they do sign. If they don't sign, we will tighten sanctions and take steps to achieve the diplomatic isolation of Serbia.

Secretary Christopher: I also wish to thank you, mister President, for your courageous decision. It is not an empty diplomatic gesture. It registered with the Russians. We will press for passage of the No Fly Zone within one week. The No Fly Zone is important symbolically; it may also help somewhat on the ground. We hope this series of steps will pay off. If not, we'll see what other steps are required. We'll increase the pressure if Serbia doesn't sign. We will consult with our allies about lifting the arms embargo. We cannot act unilaterally on this issue, however. We will commence discussions if they don't sign soon.

President Izetbegovic: We would welcome a statement from you which supports our action. People back home have doubts. We have had bad experiences with past negotiations. People who are suffering are unsure that this signature is a step towards peace. But they trust the US; they do not trust the European Community. A general statement of what you will do would be helpful and appreciated.

Vice President Gore: Secretary Christopher has already released such a statement. I will make a statement that this is a step towards peace, as well. This was the right decision, the right step. I am convinced of that.

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: I have no doubt that American diplomacy helped us reach this agreement. I thank Secretary Christopher and Ambassador Bartholomew. It's up to the international community now. Our relations with Croatia are very important at this point. Many things in the field and otherwise

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depend on our relations with Croatia. Your help in this issue is crucial. Croatian leaders have a way of backing away under pressure and then coming back later.

Ambassador Bartholomew: I agree that the Bosnian-Croat relationship is crucial and that we can help.

Vice President Gore: How?

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: We have had trouble with extreme nationalist Croatian groups in Bosnia. A direct reminder to Zagreb can help.

President Izetbegovic: Cooperations with Zagreb is vital. Other than Sarajevo, no airport in Bosnia is working. All communications comes through either Serbia or Croatia. They use this to give concessions to nationalist Croatians. This could lead to a wider conflict.

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: We are in a very desperate financial situation. We would like for Arab friends to contribute. They are reluctant to interfere in Europe unless invited by the White House. This would be a very concrete way to help us. Today in Bosnia there is no production, there is no income, yet people need to eat. Also, opening your embassy in Sarajevo would be very helpful, the EC would follow.

Ambassador Bartholomew: The security dimension is what he's describing here. These moves would have the impact described.

Secretary Christopher: What cities?

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: Sarajevo.

Ambassador Bartholomew: I've been through bombardments as bad as Sarajevo. There are ways to protect our people. It would be a very helpful symbol.

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: We would like to combine implementation of the agreement with the No Fly Zone; that would give it teeth.

Secretary Christopher: I didn't want to link the No Fly Zone with something else. That could cause delay. Would you still want it if it delays the No Fly Zone by a week?

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: We can wait.

Secretary Christopher: The delay might give the Serbs a chance to sign; to come to their senses.

Ambassador Bartholomew: I feel we should press for the No Fly Zone as soon as possible.

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Secretary Christopher: I like the concept.

Vice President Gore: It is a very interesting concept.

President Izetbegovic: My obsession is Eastern Bosnia. Horrible things will follow the fall of towns there. 100,000 people will flee to Croatia; to try to escape. Aggression must be stopped while we wait for the Serbs to sign. Otherwise there will be the biggest human tragedy in Europe since the Second World War. The Bosnian Army cannot fight for months without help.

Ambassador Sacirbey: The arms embargo is the problem.

President Izetbegovic: Even a partial lifting of the embargo, perhaps ammunition, would be very helpful.

Vice President Gore: We are following a sequence. First try to convince the Serbs to sign the agreement. Once they sign, the US is committed to help implement the agreement. We can turn to lifting the arms embargo after we've made efforts to get the Serbs to sign.

Ambassador Bartholomew: We've already told our allies that we will look at lifting the embargo if the Serbs don't sign.

Ambassador Sacirbey: We're preoccupied with our survival. The next step is defining the principles underlying our constitution. If the Serbs sign, we'll wish for your strong endorsement of implementing democratic principles rather than accepting a purely political document.

Foreign Minister Silajdzic: We do not want totalitarianism or nationalism. We want democracy.

President Izetbegovic: We suffered tyranny under the other system, now we want democracy.

Secretary Christopher: What is your assessment of the situation at Sarajevo and at the Tulza airport?

President Izetbegovic: Sarajevo is very dangerous; they may split the city into two parts. Several days ago there was the worst shelling since the beginning of the war. Some of our officers and soldiers believe they will try to occupy the city. But to try to take the city it would be very difficult for them and us. They would have to fight house to house. Yesterday the situation was a bit more calm.

Use of the airfield at Tulza would be very helpful. Supplies could come to us. Use of the airfield would also be a valuable sign that things are being done. Yes, we can hold it. It is not now in direct danger.

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At this point President Clinton entered the room and shook hands with President Izetbegovic, after which they departed together to the Oval Office.

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Leon Fuerth

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